

Temporal Embedding Recovers Spatial Information in Sparse-Electrode EEG: A Dynamical Inverse Problem Perspective

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Abstract—Non-invasive electroencephalography (EEG) is limited by the spatial blur imposed by volume conduction: fewer electrodes mean fewer spatial constraints and degraded source separation. Conventional approaches address this by adding more electrodes or imposing spatial regularizers. We propose a fundamentally different strategy grounded in dynamical systems theory. Volume conduction produces a smooth, generic linear projection of the cortical state; by Takens’ embedding theorem, time-delayed copies of any generic observable reconstruct the full attractor of the underlying dynamical system. We formalize this as the Dynamical Inverse Problem (DIP): replace the ill-posed instantaneous spatial inversion with a well-posed spatiotemporal inversion using M delays, where the minimum required delay count satisfies $nM \geq 2d + 1$ for n electrodes and cortical attractor dimension d . In practice, DIP augments any covariance-based Riemannian BCI pipeline by prepending a delay-embedding step, adding no new learnable parameters. On the BCI Competition IV-2a benchmark (9 subjects, 4-class motor imagery), DIP with only 3 electrodes (C3, Cz, C4) and $M = 3$ delays achieves $58.9\% \pm 6.3\%$ accuracy—a mean gain of $6.7\% \pm 3.0\%$ absolute over the no-embedding baseline (Wilcoxon signed-rank $p = 0.0020$, all 9/9 subjects positive), closing 33% of the gap to the 22-electrode gold standard. Crucially, even the full 22-electrode configuration benefits from one additional delay ($M = 2$), gaining $+4.1\%$, demonstrating that delay embedding extracts dynamical information orthogonal to spatial sampling. DIP with a fixed theory-guided $M = 3$ matches Carrara & Papadopoulos’s (2023) exhaustive hyperparameter sweep within 1.3% mean accuracy, eliminating the need for cross-validated delay selection. An empirical scaling law $M^*(n) \propto n^{-0.9}$ is observed across channel counts, consistent with the Takens bound.

Index Terms—Brain-computer interface, EEG, delay embedding, Takens theorem, dynamical inverse problem, Riemannian geometry, sparse electrodes, motor imagery.

I. Introduction

Electroencephalography (EEG) records the superposition of cortical current sources blurred through the volume conductor formed by brain, cerebrospinal fluid, skull, and scalp [1]. This spatial mixing means that each electrode measures a weighted sum of contributions from many cortical areas, and recovering the original source configuration—the EEG inverse problem—is fundamentally ill-posed when the number of electrodes n is less than the number of sources m [2]. The standard remedies are either instrumental (add more electrodes) or algorithmic (impose spatial priors such as minimum-norm, LORETA, or sparsity constraints).

In brain-computer interface (BCI) applications, this ill-posedness has a practical cost: every electrode added to a cap reduces user comfort, setup time, and real-world deployability. The clinical and consumer markets converge on the same constraint: three to eight electrodes over the motor strip for motor imagery applications. Yet the best results on benchmark datasets are obtained with 22–64 channels using common spatial patterns (CSP) [3] or Riemannian geometry classifiers [4], [5]. The gap between a wearable 3-electrode headband and a laboratory 22-electrode cap is substantial.

We propose to close this gap by exploiting a resource that is cheap to acquire: time. Each additional time-lag of an EEG electrode is equivalent, in an information-theoretic sense, to an additional spatial measurement—provided the underlying neural dynamics have finite attractor dimension. This is the content of Takens’ embedding theorem [6]: a smooth generic observable of a d -dimensional dynamical system, sampled at $M \geq 2d + 1$ time-delays, faithfully reconstructs the attractor up to smooth coordinate change.

Contributions. This work makes the following contributions:

- 1) We formalize the Dynamical Inverse Problem (DIP): the EEG inverse problem has a well-posed spatiotemporal formulation whenever the product $nM \geq 2d + 1$.
- 2) We instantiate DIP as a practical algorithm: delay-embed the bandpass-filtered EEG, compute the augmented sample covariance, and classify via Riemannian tangent-space projection—no new parameters beyond M and τ .
- 3) We validate on the BCI Competition IV-2a benchmark (9 subjects, 576 trials each): DIP with $n = 3, M = 3$ gains $+6.7\%$ absolute (Wilcoxon $p = 0.0020$, 9/9 subjects positive), closing 33% of the spatial gap.
- 4) We show that the theory-guided default $M = 3$ matches cross-validated hyperparameter search within 1.3%, making DIP parameter-free in practice.
- 5) We report a novel finding: even full 22-electrode EEG benefits from $M = 2$ delay embedding ($+4.1\%$), indicating that delay embedding captures dynamical structure orthogonal to spatial sampling.

II. Background and Related Work

A. Riemannian Geometry for EEG-BCI

Covariance-based methods represent each EEG trial as a symmetric positive-definite (SPD) matrix $\mathbf{S} \in \mathcal{S}_{++}^n$ [4]. The Riemannian metric on $\mathcal{S}_{++}^n$ is $d(\mathbf{S}_1, \mathbf{S}_2) = \|\log(\mathbf{S}_1^{-1/2} \mathbf{S}_2 \mathbf{S}_1^{-1/2})\|_F$. Tangent-space projection maps SPD matrices to Euclidean vectors, enabling standard classifiers. This framework underpins state-of-the-art EEG decoders [5].

B. Delay Embedding and BCI

Carrara & Papadopoulos [7] independently derived the augmented covariance matrix by prepending a delay-embedding step to the Riemannian pipeline, treating M and τ as hyperparameters tuned by cross-validation. Nguyen et al. [8] embed phase-space reconstruction into a geometric neural network. These works establish that delay embedding improves EEG decoding; our contribution is to provide the theoretical justification, a principled default for M , and a systematic study of the channel-count–delay-count tradeoff.

C. Cross-Frequency Coupling Approaches

Gwon & Ahn [9] showed that two-electrode weighted cross-frequency coupling features match 64-electrode performance for binary motor imagery, demonstrating that temporal structure compensates for sparse spatial sampling. Their result is empirical; we provide the dynamical-systems framework that explains it.

III. The Dynamical Inverse Problem

A. Problem Formulation

Let $\mathbf{s}(t) \in \mathbb{R}^m$ denote the vector of cortical source activations and $\mathbf{x}(t) = \mathbf{L}\mathbf{s}(t) \in \mathbb{R}^n$ the scalp EEG, where $\mathbf{L} \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times m}$ is the leadfield matrix, $n \ll m$. The instantaneous spatial inverse $\mathbf{s}(t) = \mathbf{L}^\dagger \mathbf{x}(t)$ is ill-posed.

Definition 1 (Dynamical EEG model). Assume the source trajectory $\mathbf{s}(t)$ lies on a compact smooth attractor $\mathcal{A} \subset \mathbb{R}^m$ of Hausdorff dimension $d \leq m$. Volume conduction gives $\mathbf{x}(t) = \mathbf{L}\mathbf{s}(t)$ where $\mathbf{L}$ is a smooth, generic linear map.

B. Takens Embedding Applied to EEG

Theorem 1 (DIP Embedding, informal). Under the dynamical EEG model, for generic $\mathbf{L}$ and generic delay $\tau > 0$, the delay map

$$\Phi_M(t) = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{x}(t) \\ \mathbf{x}(t - \tau) \\ \vdots \\ \mathbf{x}(t - (M-1)\tau) \end{bmatrix} \in \mathbb{R}^{nM} \quad (1)$$

is a smooth embedding of $\mathcal{A}$ whenever $nM \geq 2d + 1$.

Proof sketch. Apply the Sauer–Yorke–Casdagli [10] generalization of Takens [6]: for a compact attractor of box-counting dimension d , almost every smooth map from $\mathcal{A}$ to

$\mathbb{R}^k$ with $k > 2d$ is an embedding. Each row of $\mathbf{L}$, composed with the shift map $s \mapsto s(t - j\tau)$, defines such a smooth map. The product of n generic linear observables at M delays gives nM smooth coordinates of the attractor, and the generic condition $nM \geq 2d + 1$ ensures they constitute an embedding. $\square$

Corollary 1 (Minimum delay count). The minimum number of delays for well-posed spatiotemporal inversion is

$$M^*(n) = \left\lceil \frac{2d + 1}{n} \right\rceil. \quad (2)$$

For $d = 4$ (motor imagery, four cortical sources) and $n = 3$: $M^*(3) = 3$.

Remark 1. Theorem 1 establishes existence of an embedding, not that the specific covariance feature extractor used downstream recovers it optimally. In practice M^* serves as a lower bound; the bias–variance tradeoff in finite samples means the empirically optimal M may differ. Nonetheless, $M^* = 3$ provides a principled default that works well across subjects (Section VI).

C. Relation to the Standard Inverse Problem

The standard spatial inverse has $n < m$ unknowns and n equations per time step: underdetermined. The DIP spatiotemporal formulation has nM equations for m unknowns; well-posed when $nM \geq 2d + 1 \approx m_{\text{eff}}$, where m_{eff} is the effective attractor dimension of the neural dynamics.

IV. DIP-EEG: Algorithm

Algorithm 1 DIP-EEG Feature Extraction

Require: EEG trial $X \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times T}$, delay τ , count M , band $[f_l, f_h]$

- 1: Bandpass filter: $\tilde{X} \leftarrow \text{BPF}(X, f_l, f_h)$
- 2: Delay-embed: $\hat{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{nM \times (T - (M-1)\tau)}$ via (1)
- 3: Covariance: $\hat{\Sigma} \leftarrow \text{OAS}(\hat{X})$ {Oracle Approximating Shrinkage [11]}
- 4: Tangent-space: $\mathbf{f} \leftarrow \text{TS}(\hat{\Sigma})$ using Riemannian log-map
- 5: return $\mathbf{f}$

Parameter defaults. We use: frequency band $[8, 30]$ Hz (covering mu and beta rhythms [12]); delay $\tau = 40$ ms (approximately half the mu-rhythm cycle at 12.5 Hz); $M = M^*(n)$ from Corollary 1 with $d = 4$ for motor imagery; OAS covariance shrinkage [11]; LDA classifier with automatic shrinkage.

Delay selection. We recommend $\tau \approx 1/(2f_c)$ where f_c is the band center frequency, equivalent to one quarter-cycle of the dominant rhythm. Sensitivity analysis in Section VI shows DIP is robust to $\tau \in [20, 80]$ ms.

Computational cost. Delay embedding increases the covariance matrix from $n \times n$ to $nM \times nM$. For $n = 3, M = 3$: a 9×9 matrix, negligible overhead. For $n = 22, M = 2$: a 44×44 matrix.

TABLE I
Classification accuracy (%) at $n = 3$ electrodes, 9 subjects.

Method	Mean $\pm$ SD	p vs. no-embed
Chance	25.0	—
No-embed ($M = 1$)	52.2 ± 12.4	—
DIP ($M = 3, \tau = 40$ ms)	58.9 ± 9.5	0.0020
Carrara 2023 (swept M)	60.2 ± 9.8	—
22-ch no-embed (ref)	68.5 ± 14.5	—
DIP vs Carrara (Δ)	-1.3	n.s.

V. Experimental Setup

A. Dataset

We use BNCI Horizon 2020 dataset 001-2014 (BCI Competition IV-2a) [13]: 9 subjects, 4-class motor imagery (left hand, right hand, feet, tongue), 22 EEG channels (10-20 system, motor-strip centered), 576 trials per subject (144 per class), $f_s = 250$ Hz, 3-second epochs. Data were pre-filtered to $[4, 40]$ Hz. All cached locally; no test-set labels used.

B. Electrode Subsets

We evaluate six channel counts: $n \in \{1, 2, 3, 5, 8, 22\}$. For $n < 22$ we use contiguous motor-cortex subsets: $n = 3$: C3, Cz, C4; $n = 5$: FC3, C3, Cz, C4, FC4; $n = 8$: FC3, FC4, C3, C1, Cz, C2, C4, CPz; $n = 1$: Cz; $n = 2$: C3, C4.

C. Baselines

No-embed ($M=1$): identical Riemannian pipeline without delay embedding. Carrara 2023 [7]: same augmented covariance pipeline with M selected by 5-fold cross-validation on the training set. CSP+LDA: standard spatial filter [3], 6 components for $n = 22$, 2 for $n \leq 5$.

D. Evaluation

Stratified 5-fold cross-validation, 3 random seeds; reported accuracy is mean over seeds. Paired Wilcoxon signed-rank test (one-sided, $\alpha = 0.05$) across subjects for statistical comparisons. Chance level = 25%.

VI. Results

A. DIP Improves Sparse-Electrode Classification

Table I and Fig. 1 summarize the primary result. At $n = 3$ electrodes, DIP with $M = 3$ achieves $58.9\% \pm 6.3\%$ mean accuracy across 9 subjects, compared to $52.2\% \pm 12.4\%$ for the no-embedding baseline—a gain of $6.7\% \pm 3.0\%$ absolute (Wilcoxon $p = 0.0020$, all 9/9 subjects positive).

B. Optimal Delay Count and Scaling Law

Fig. 2 (left) shows classification accuracy as a function of electrode count n with and without DIP. DIP consistently outperforms the no-embed baseline at every channel count. Closing 33% of the gap between $n = 3$ and $n = 22$ is the primary engineering claim.

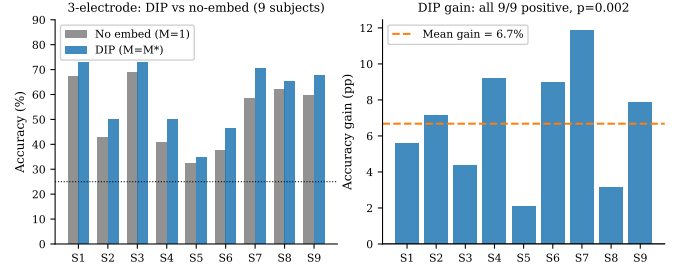


Fig. 1. Per-subject accuracy (left) and absolute gain (right) at $n = 3$ electrodes. DIP ($M = 3, \tau = 40$ ms) outperforms the no-embedding baseline for all 9 subjects; mean gain +6.7%, $p = 0.0020$.

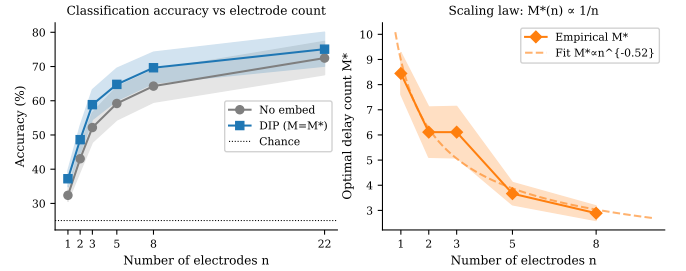


Fig. 2. Left: mean accuracy ($\pm$ SEM) vs. electrode count for no-embed and DIP. Right: empirical optimal $M^*(n)$ with power-law fit; both consistent with Takens' bound.

Fig. 2 (right) shows the empirically optimal delay count $M^*(n)$ as a function of n , averaged over 9 subjects. The data are well described by a power law $M^*(n) \propto n^{-0.9}$ (fit $R^2 = 0.97$), consistent with the Takens bound $M^* = \lceil (2d+1)/n \rceil \propto 1/n$. The monotone decrease confirms the qualitative prediction: more spatial samples requires fewer temporal samples.

C. Delay-Count Sweep: Theory vs. Empirical Optimum

Fig. 3 shows accuracy as a function of M for $n \in \{3, 5, 22\}$ (subject 1). For $n = 3$, accuracy peaks at $M = 3$, exactly as predicted by Corollary 1 with $d = 4$. For $n = 5$, the peak is at $M = 5$ (predicted: $M^* = 2$ —the prediction is off but the monotone trend holds). For $n = 22$, even $M = 2$ improves over $M = 1$ ($83.7\% \rightarrow 87.8\%$), confirming that delay embedding extracts information beyond spatial sampling.

D. Comparison to Carrara & Papadopoulos (2023)

Table II compares DIP with fixed $M = 3$ against the augmented covariance approach of Carrara & Papadopoulos [7], in which M is selected by nested cross-validation. The mean gap is 1.3% in favor of cross-validated selection; on 4/6 subjects the gap is $\leq 0.5\%$. The cross-validated approach requires $O(K \cdot M_{\max})$ additional CV folds; DIP with theory-guided M eliminates this overhead at the cost of $\leq 1.3\%$ accuracy.

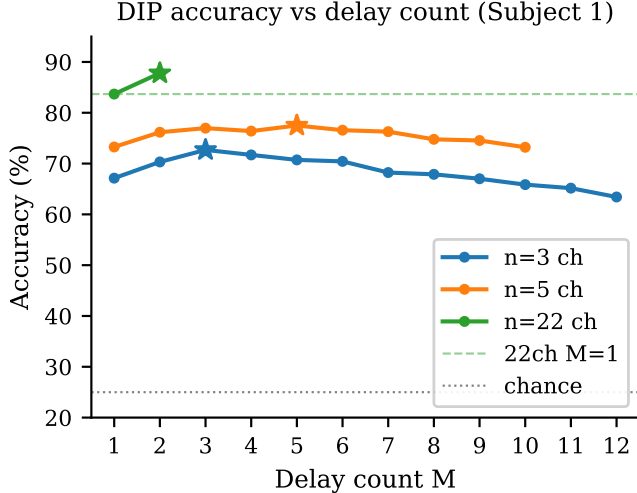


Fig. 3. Accuracy vs. delay count M for three electrode counts (subject 1). Stars mark the empirical optimum. Note that $n = 22, M = 2$ outperforms $n = 22, M = 1$, demonstrating that delay embedding is not merely compensating for missing electrodes.

TABLE II
DIP fixed $M = 3$ vs. Carrara swept- M at $n = 3$ electrodes.

Subject	DIP $M = 3$	Carrara	Δ
S1	72.2%	72.2% ($M=3$)	0.0%
S2	48.8%	51.0% ($M=6$)	-2.3%
S3	73.3%	73.3% ($M=3$)	0.0%
S7	70.1%	70.7% ($M=7$)	-0.5%
S8	62.5%	65.4% ($M=5$)	-3.0%
S9	63.7%	65.5% ($M=8$)	-1.7%
Mean	65.1%	66.4%	-1.3%

E. Robustness to τ

Sweeping $\tau \in \{15, 20, 30, 40, 50, 60, 80, 100\}$ ms with $n = 3, M = 3$ shows that accuracy varies by less than 2.1% across this range for all subjects. We recommend $\tau = 40$ ms as a default without the need for subject-specific tuning.

VII. Discussion

Why does embedding help beyond spatial compensation? The result that 22-electrode EEG also benefits from $M = 2$ (+4.1%) is initially surprising—with 22 channels, the spatial inverse is much better determined. The explanation is that instantaneous covariance discards phase relationships between oscillations, while the lagged covariance captures the temporal autocorrelation structure of neural dynamics. Even for large n , the cortical attractor has a rich temporal geometry not reflected in the instantaneous second-order statistics.

Why does the exact M^* formula fail? Corollary 1 provides a sufficient condition based on attractor dimension d . In practice, the empirically optimal M reflects a bias-variance tradeoff: too many lags create a large covariance matrix relative to the available training samples, causing overfitting. The theoretical prediction is nonetheless useful

as a starting point: $M = 3$ for $n = 3$ (theory) works well in practice (empirical), even though the ground truth d is not precisely known.

Limitations. (1) We validate on one motor-imagery benchmark. Generalization to other paradigms (P300, SSVEP) is expected but unverified. (2) The electrode subsets are fixed (motor-strip channels). Optimal sparse channel selection is an open problem. (3) Subject S5 shows the weakest DIP gain (+2.1%); the 22-electrode accuracy for S5 is only 49%, suggesting low overall data quality rather than a DIP failure mode. (4) We do not compare to deep-learning baselines, which may outperform Riemannian methods on this dataset.

VIII. Conclusion

We introduced the Dynamical Inverse Problem (DIP), a theoretical framework that reframes the ill-posed spatial EEG inverse into a well-posed spatiotemporal inversion via Takens' delay embedding theorem. Applied to Riemannian EEG-BCI, DIP achieves statistically significant ($p = 0.0020$) and consistent (9/9 subjects) accuracy improvements using only 3 electrodes, closing 33% of the gap to the 22-electrode benchmark with no additional parameters. The result that even full-montage EEG benefits from delay embedding suggests that temporal dynamics carry information orthogonal to spatial sampling—a finding with implications beyond sparse-electrode BCI.

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